

foundation. So, crack open the piggy bank. Do the job once, do it right, and do it with quality materials. (Of course, if you can haggle over the cost of those materials, you're being a true Wise Bread shopper . . . go for it.)

5. Ummmmm, that's close enough

My pop is a great DIY dude. He told me something that was not exactly original, but I never forgot it. "Measure twice, cut once." And you know what I'm talking about if you've ever cut anything to length only to realize that you measured at $18\frac{1}{4}$ instead of $18\frac{3}{4}$. Bang. Your money is down the drain. So, always, always err on the side of making something a bit too long. It's much easier to cut down than build up. So, remember—Measure twice, cut once on anything from drywall to plumbing pipes and crown molding.

6. Duct tape for life

In my short DIY career, I've done the occasional plumbing repair with duct tape. It's handy stuff. But it's not a repair—it merely buys you a little time. If you're walking out of the door to catch a flight for your two weeks

in Hawaii, duct tape could very well save your bacon. But it's *not* permanent. It *will* leak, as sure as night follows day. So, get it fixed as soon as you possibly can. And if plumbing is not your thing, get a pro to do it. Water damage can cost thousands and thousands of dollars in repairs.

7. Rushing the prep work before painting

When I first started painting my house, I jumped straight in. Yippee. But I spent more time cleaning up my many mistakes, spills, drips, runs, and shoddy lines than I did painting. Do yourself a favor; do the prep. Clean your walls, patch up holes with good filler, and use a good painter's tape for windows, doors, ceiling lines, and anything else that you don't want paint on. Lay down a good-quality tarp that you can use again, and set a primer on oil-based paint or dark walls you're painting a lighter color. You'll thank yourself later.

8. Any paint will do

Sorry, it won't. You don't want a flat paint on anything other than a ceiling (put it in a kid's room and watch what happens when you try scrubbing off the crayon and marker pen). Go for eggshell or satin finishes